



Shenyang J-35

The **Shenyang J-35** (Chinese: 歼-35; pinyin: *jiān-sānwǔ*) is a series of Chinese single-seater, twin-engine, all-weather, stealth multirole combat aircraft manufactured by Shenyang Aircraft Corporation (SAC), designed for air superiority and surface strike missions. The aircraft has two variants, a land-based variant designed for the People's Liberation Army Air Force (PLAAF), and a carrier-based variant optimized for catapult-assisted takeoff (CATOBAR) for the People's Liberation Army Naval Air Force (PLANAF). The aircraft is also promoted for export.

The aircraft was developed from the **FC-31 Gyrfalcon** (Chinese: 鹞鹰; pinyin: *Gǎoyīng*),^{[4][5][6][7][8]} a stealth aircraft prototype that served as a demonstrator aiming to secure potential export customers after SAC lost the J-XX bid to the Chengdu Aircraft Industry Group.

The People's Liberation Army, particularly the PLA Navy, later took an interest in the FC-31 project, leading to the prototype being further developed with a catapult launch bar and folding wings, and the revised variant took flight on 29 October 2021.^[2] A land-based variant emerged in 2023^{[3][9]} and was officially debuted ahead of the 2024 China International Aviation & Aerospace Exhibition, receiving the designation J-35A.^[10] The aircraft was unofficially called J-31 by some media and analysts until the official name announced as the J-35.^{[11][12]}

The introduction of the J-35 in June 2025^[13] makes it the second Chinese fifth-generation fighter (after the Chengdu J-20) and China the only country other than the United States to use two types of stealth fighters.^{[14][15]}

Shenyang J-35



J-35A at 2024 Zhuhai Air Show

General information

Type	Multirole stealth fighter
National origin	China
Manufacturer	Shenyang Aircraft Corporation
Designer	601st Design Institute
Status	In service
Primary user	People's Liberation Army Air Force People's Liberation Army Naval Air Force
Number built	8+

History

Manufactured	2012–2016 (FC-31) 2021–present (J-35)
Introduction date	2025
First flight	31 October 2012 (FC-31) ^[1] 29 October 2021 (J-35) ^[2] 26 September 2023 (J-35A) ^[3]
Developed from	Shenyang FC-31

Development

Designation

The prototype of the J-35 had often been referred to as *J-31*,^[note 1] *F-60*, *J-21*, *Snowy Owl* or *Falcon Hawk* in various media reports.^{[17][18][19][20]} The fighter initially did not feature the J-XX nomenclatures, as such names are reserved for programs launched and financed by the military, while the FC-31 was developed independently as a privately funded venture by SAC.^{[21][22]} The original FC-31 prototype made its maiden flight on October 31, 2012.^[1]

Origin

While the Chengdu J-20 stealth fighter was officially endorsed by the PLAAF after Chengdu Aerospace Corporation's proposal won the PLAAF bid for the next-generation jet fighter,^[23] Shenyang Aircraft Corporation pressed on and developed a private project aiming to secure potential export customers.^[21]

In September 2011, Shenyang Aircraft Corporation presented the scale model of the FC-31, dubbed the "F-60" at an innovation competition held in Beijing.^{[24][25]}

In June 2012, a partially assembled F-60 was photographed in a police-escorted road transit through a national highway atop a truck and trailer, with its airframe heavily overwrapped by camouflage covering. Initially, military observers speculated the subject in transit was the Hongdu JL-10 trainer aircraft.^[26] A few days later, pictures of a fully assembled fighter aircraft parking on an airfield emerged on the internet, with the new aircraft displaying stealth characteristics, the registration number "31001" on the front fuselage.^[25] Military observers gave temporary names to the aircraft, such as J-21, J-31, or F-60. Several features were also noted, such as the more conventional airframe design with trapezoidal wings (instead of the canard-delta configuration of the Chengdu J-20) and twin nose wheels,^{[25][27]} leading to the speculation that F-60 could become a carrier-borne aircraft in the future.^[28]

On 31 October 2012, The first prototype made its maiden flight, accompanied by a J-11 serving as the chase aircraft.^[29]

Shenyang FC-31

In November 2012, The aircraft was officially revealed at Zhuhai Airshow 2012, with the designation Shenyang FC-31, following Chinese export fighter terminology and aircraft such as FC-1 and FC-20.^[25] A scale model of the FC-31 was displayed inside the exhibition hall.^[30]

On 12 November 2014, the FC-31 prototype performed its first public flight demonstration at Zhuhai Airshow 2014.^{[31][32][33]} The prototype was fitted with two Klimov RD-93 engines. Reuben Johnson of *Aviation International News* noted the prototype was not optimized in its flight performance. The author also noted that another model with modified details was displayed inside the exhibition hall.^[34]

In 2015, the FC-31 model was displayed first time at a foreign military trade expo, at Dubai Airshow. AVIC official told *Aviation Week* that the company was pushing the aircraft for export while negotiating with the Chinese government and the People's Liberation Army for further development. Some additional

details were given by the FC-31's designer, including its stealth capabilities, payload, and operational range.^{[35][36]} The aircraft was intended to serve as a competitor to the Lockheed Martin F-35 on the export market, especially for countries which cannot join the F-35 program or afford the American fighter.^{[37][38][39][40][41]}



Shenyang FC-31 performing at Zhuhai Airshow 2014

There were also persistent rumors of the FC-31 being developed into a carrier-based naval fighter. In 2015, the FC-31's chief designer Sun Cong suggested that FC-31 would succeed Shenyang J-15 in operating on China's aircraft carriers.^{[31][42][43]}

In 2015, Jiangsu A-Star Aviation Industries Company marketed its EOTS-86 infra-red search and track as a possible addition to the FC-31.^[44]

In November 2016, AVIC released a promotional video of an FC-31 prototype, displaying the refinement in construction quality from earlier prototypes.^[45]

On 23 December 2016, the second prototype of the FC-31 took flight.^{[41][25]} The second prototype features several revisions and upgrades to the aircraft design.^[41] The inefficient RD-93 engine was replaced by two smokeless WS-13E engines, the canopy was changed from the two-piece design to a reinforced single-piece glass, and the control surface configuration was overhauled, now with clipped and swept vertical tails instead of the trapezoid tails. Other improvements included modifications to the vertical stabilizers, wings, and airframe, an electro-optical targeting system, a larger payload, improvements in stealth, and upgraded electronics.^{[46][47]} This airframe was eventually painted in low-visibility color with pennant number '31003', leading to speculations of an unseen static test prototype being the '31002'.^[25] This prototype was not featured in the Zhuhai Airshow of 2016.^[48] Still, a cockpit model with a sidestick controller, multifunctional touchscreen displays, and a heads-up display was showcased in the AVIC booth.^[48]

The real '31001' prototype aircraft was displayed on the ground in Shenyang, China in 2016.^[49] It was displayed again at Zhuhai Airshow 2018, implying China no longer deemed first prototype sensitive technologically.^[50]

On 21 November 2018, the Aviation Week reported that People's Liberation Army (PLA) has taken interest in the Shenyang FC-31.^[51]

By February 2022, AVIC continued to promote FC-31 for export.^[52]

Shenyang J-35

In June 2020, the Chinese Aeronautical Establishment, the research wing of the Aviation Industry Corporation of China (AVIC), announced that a "new fighter" is under development and will make its maiden flight in 2021. This "new fighter" was theorized by media and military analysts as the navalized version of the Shenyang FC-31.^{[53][54]} Due to the lack of an official announcement, military analysis

hypothetically designated this variant as 'J-35' or 'J-XY'.^[25] New reports indicated that the new variant would feature a bigger radome, navalized functions, and different alignments of control surfaces to reduce the radar signature.^{[55][56]}

In June 2021, a mock-up of the FC-31 (J-35) prototype was spotted parked on top of China's carrier test facility, which simulates the flight deck of the Type 003 aircraft carrier.^[57] Analysts believe the J-35 could serve in China's future Type 003 aircraft carrier, as well as launched with ski-jump on China's older carriers, complementing the fleet of Shenyang J-15.^[58] In July 2021, a static FC-31 with opened weapons bay was displayed inside the Shenyang Aircraft Corporation Expo Park. Analysts noted the similarity of the weapons bay dimension between Chengdu J-20 and FC-31, which means the fighter could accommodate PL-15 missiles and other armaments in similar quantities.^[59]

On 29 October 2021, the modified carrier-based variant of the FC-31, tentatively named J-35, conducted its maiden flight.^{[60][61]} This new prototype, in blue-green primer paint, features a major redesign. A catapult launch bar and folding wing mechanisms were added, intended for operating on the Type 003 aircraft carrier with its electromagnetic catapult system. A chin-mounted sensor turret, similar to the Electro-Optical Targeting System (EOTS) on F-35, is featured.^[2] The canopy was modified, blending in with the upper fuselage, allowing for more internal fuel load, aerodynamic advantages, and potential to mount sensors behind the cockpit.^[62] The overall shape of the first J-35 prototype indicated a developmental lineage from the second prototype of the FC-31.^{[2][63]}

On 22 July 2022, the J-35 prototype '350003' was spotted by military analysts. This new prototype was reportedly the second flying prototype and the third overall prototype of the navalized J-35 variant. The new prototype was also painted in the People's Liberation Army Navy (PLAN) grey camouflage, with the PLAN's 'flying shark' logo visible on its vertical stabilizers. The '350003' features sawtooth edges for compartment panels, seamless exteriors, and new engines, reportedly WS-21 or WS-13X, which is a further development of the WS-13E mounted on the second prototype of the FC-31. This engine is fitted with pronounced, serrated exhaust nozzles, helping to reduce rearward radar and infrared signatures.^{[64][65]} A video of the prototype flying was recorded on the same day.^[66]



Navalized prototype of the Shenyang J-35 stealth fighter

In March 2023, the People's Liberation Army Navy released a recruitment video, teasing about the service's future carrier aircraft, which included a rough outline of the FC-31.^{[67][68]}

In August 2023, a J-35 prototype was spotted test flying with landing gear extended in China.^[69] On 8 December 2023, a mock-up of the J-35 was spotted on the deck of the Type 003 aircraft carrier, which was recently launched and preparing for sea trials at her homeport.^[70]

On 26 September 2023, the land-based variant of the J-35, tentatively named the J-31 by defense analysts, made its first flight. The land-based variant was distinguished by its smaller wing surface area, single nose wheel, and non-clipped wings, different from the earlier J-35 prototype.^{[3][9][71]}

On 13 February 2024, a full-size mockup of the navalized J-35 fighter was spotted aboard China's aircraft carrier Liaoning, under evaluation for potential use on the aircraft deck. The test of the J-35 on *Liaoning* signified that the fighter is intended to operate not only on catapult-equipped Type 003 but also the older ski-jump (STOBAR) carriers. Analysts also believed the smaller size and lighter weight of the J-35 could provide operational advantages on the *Liaoning* and *Shandong*.^[72] A few days later on 29 February 2024, the *Liaoning* embarked to the sea, carrying the J-35 mock-up for further testing.^[73] On 13 March 2024, military analysts noted the third flying prototype of the J-35 testing near Shenyang's facilities.^[74]

On 5 November 2024, the People's Liberation Army Air Force (PLAAF) officially announced the J-35A, the air force variant of the J-35, would attend the Zhuhai Airshow in 2024 held in the same month.^{[75][76]} The close-up photograph of the J-35A showcased by the PLAAF was painted in grey paint with the Air Force's roundel with the number '75' engraved on the vertical stabilizers, celebrating PLAAF's 75th anniversary.^{[77][78]} Photographs confirmed the differences with earlier naval J-35 on wing size, nose wheel, and vertical stabilizer design.^[10] On 12 November 2024, the J-35A conducted its first public flight performance at the Zhuhai Airshow.^{[79][80][81][82]}

Design

Overview

The Shenyang J-35 development program was initiated as the Shenyang FC-31 project, an export-oriented demonstrator funded by private ventures. There were constant revisions between the prototypes and the later models commissioned by the Chinese military, as different parties had divergent demands and requirements. The navalized J-35 and land-based J-35A were also developed in parallel with different missions and roles, corresponding to their intended operational environment.^{[25][64][83]} In total, there were four notable variants of the FC-31/J-35 development cycle, including the first flying prototype '31001', referred as FC-31 V1 by analysts;^[25] The second flying prototype '31003', often referred as FC-31 V2;^[25] and the two variants of the land and carrier-based J-35 fighters,^{[64][9]} which were known as the J-35A and J-35, respectively.^[84]

The Shenyang FC-31 is a medium-sized aircraft, smaller than the Chengdu J-20, and designed to complement the latter with a lower cost and simpler operations.^[85] The twinjet aircraft features a conventional configuration with a blended body and a chiseled nose section, followed by forward-swept intake ramp, diverterless supersonic inlet (DSI) bumps, trapezoidal wings with leading/trailing-edge flaps, all-moving tail-planes, and two canted swept-back vertical stabilizers (the first prototype has triangle stabilizers) with truncated rudders (full-length



Shenyang FC-31 performing at Zhuhai Airshow 2014



Shenyang J-35A performing at Zhuhai Airshow 2024

rudders on the naval J-35).^{[86][87][78]} The initial prototype featured a two-piece canopy, later replaced by a single-piece bubble canopy on the second prototype^[25] and the clamshell-type canopy on the J-35 and J-35A.^[87]

The FC-31 prototype has a twin-wheel nose landing gear, giving provision for the fighter's navalization as a carrier-based fighter.^[28] The twin-wheel design was later preserved in the naval Shenyang J-35 design,^[62] with a catapult launch bar added.^[2] The naval J-35 also features handholds inside the cockpit,^[88] folded wings, and a recovery tailhook to operate on the aircraft carrier.^{[2][77]} On the land-based Shenyang J-35A, the wheel section is replaced by a single-wheel design,^[9] and the variant also features a smaller wing area and different vertical stabilizers.^[10] Though two variants have separate missions and roles, the shared platform allows easier cross-service joint operations, according to the AVIC.^[83]

Stealth

The Shenyang FC-31 features low-observable aircraft designs, focusing on the reduction of the radar cross-section (RCS). To achieve stealth, the control surfaces are edge-aligned, and engine blades are hidden by the serpentine inlets (S-ducts) behind the diverterless supersonic inlets (DSI) bumps, which obscure the reflective surface of the engine from radar detection. The airframe and its internal weapons bay, compartment doors, and embedded antennas are lined with sawtooth edges and covered with radar-absorbent coating materials, both structurally "baked in" and applied externally.^{[47][56][64][89]} The early prototype featured simple round engine nozzles, which were redesigned on the later models with serrated edges to reduce radar and infrared signatures.^[90] AVIC claims the aircraft is stealthy against L-band and Ku-band radars, and would be low-observable against many multi-spectrum sensors.^{[35][77]} The Shenyang J-35 inherits the FC-31 design with a smooth surface and low-observable characteristics.^{[78][77]} A radar reflector (Luneburg lens) is fitted underneath the J-35 to mask its signatures.^[77]

Avionics

The Shenyang FC-31 and Shenyang J-35 are fitted with an active electronically scanned array (AESA) radar with a distributed aperture system (DAS)^[87] serving as an optical early-warning system^[86] and infrared search and track (IRST).^[91] The radar advertised for the FC-31 prototype is the Nanjing Research Institute of Electronics Technology (NRIET) KLJ-7A, which is reportedly similar to performance of the AN/APG-81.^[86] Under the chin, the fighter is fitted with a electro-optical targeting system (EOTS) turret.^{[2][86][77]} Inside the cockpit, there is a sidestick controller, a conventional heads up display, and a large single-piece multi-function touchscreen display (MFD) of 20 in × 8 in (510 mm × 200 mm) in size.^{[48][91][92]} The pilot is also provided with a helmet-mounted display and sight (HMD/S) system, comparable to that of Striker system made by BAE Systems.^{[86][91]} The flight control system is fully digitalized, with triple redundancy modules and twin data bus.^[92] The aircraft is intended to serve as a node in the network of elements with other platforms,^[83] playing a key role in Chinese military's kill chain.^[93]

Engines

Two prototypes of the FC-31 and the later Shenyang J-35 use different engine options. The earliest prototype was fitted with Klimov RD-93 engines.^[94] The RD-93 engine was reportedly inefficient, leading to the aircraft to exhale black-colored exhaust.^{[34][95][96]} Replacing the engine with a more

efficient, indigenous choices became a priority for the Aviation Industry Corporation of China (AVIC).^[97]

The second FC-31 prototype is fitted with the domestic Guizhou WS-13E engine,^[64] an improved variant of the Guizhou WS-13 that powered the JF-17, providing 87.2 kN (19,600 lbf; 8,890 kgf) of maximum thrust. The WS-13E engine is smokeless and more efficient than the RD-93.^{[41][25]}

The further developed Shenyang J-35 was initially powered by the Guizhou WS-21 engine, also known as the WS-13X, a derivative and upgrade of the WS-13E.^[64] The WS-21 provides 93.2 kN (21,000 lbf; 9,500 kgf) of thrust,^[88] and served as an interim powerplant for the early production J-35.^[64]

The final production powerplant^[98] for the J-35 is the Guizhou WS-19,^[99] an engine capable of producing approximately 110–116 kN (25,000–26,000 lbf; 11,200–11,800 kgf) of thrust with a higher thrust-to-weight ratio.^{[88][100]} The J-35 is reportedly capable of supercruise with the WS-19 engines fitted.^[78]

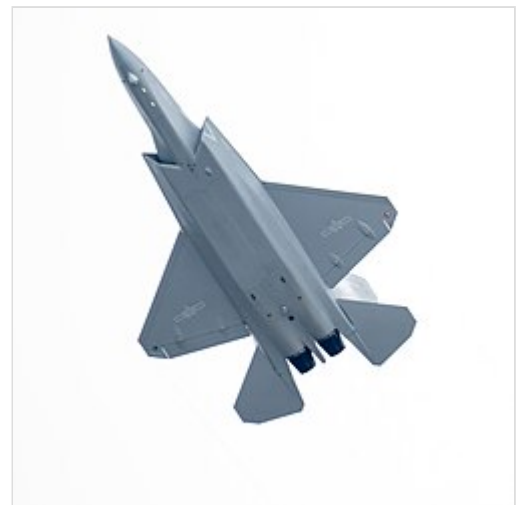
The J-35 is equipped with a retractable refueling probe for inflight refueling. The aircraft can achieve a short-take off distance of 450 m (1,480 ft) and a landing distance of 700 m (2,300 ft).^[92]

Armaments and payload

The Shenyang FC-31 has a lengthened centerline internal weapons bay^[101] with a dimension similar to that of Chengdu J-20.^{[59][84][78]} The weapons bay has six internal hardpoints. Externally, the fighter has six hardpoints on the wings. The first FC-31 prototype can reportedly carry 8,000 kg (18,000 lb) of payload in total, split between the internal carrying capabilities of 2,000 kg (4,400 lb) and external carrying capacity of 6,000 kg (13,000 lb). Under the regular combat load, the fighter has a combat radius of 648 nmi (746 mi; 1,200 km) and maximum take-off weight of 25,000 kg (55,000 lb).^{[35][36]} On the second prototype, the maximum take-off weight is increased to 28,000 kg (62,000 lb) along with a modified fuselage.^[86]

Inside the weapons bay, the J-35 can carry six air-to-air missiles,^{[86][102]} such as PL-10, PL-15 and PL-21.^{[102][103]}

Apart from air-superiority loadouts, the internal bay can also carry precision-strike munitions, with maximum provisions for twelve small diameter bombs, four large deep-penetration bombs of 500 kg (1,100 lb), four supersonic land-attack missiles, or four anti-radiation/anti-ship missiles. Externally, the wings allow the maximum provisions of six air-to-air missiles, 18 small bombs, four large bombs of 500 kg (1,100 lb), or four land-attack missiles. Presumably, the operator can mix the combinations of armaments according to the missions.^[86] Aside from underslung weapons, speculative observations also believe an autocannon is located above the port-side air intake.^[104]



Ventral weapons bay of the Shenyang J-35A

Operational history

Flight testing

The prototype conducted a high-speed taxiing test and briefly became airborne. On 31 October 2012, prototype No. 31001 conducted the model's maiden flight.^{[18][105][106]} It was accompanied by two J-11 fighters in a ten-minute test flight with its landing gear lowered.

With the maiden test flight of prototype No. 31001 on 30 October 2012, China became the second nation after the United States to have two stealth fighter designs in field testing at the same time.^[105] The aircraft continued a limited test program, with footage emerging of further flights that took place in February 2013.^[107]

On 23 December 2016, the second prototype of the FC-31, No. 31003,^[47] took its maiden flight.^[25] The second prototype featured a modified airframe, with different engines, cockpit, wings, avionics, electronics, and overall dimensions.^{[41][46][47]} The aircraft length was increased from 16.8 m (55 ft) to 17.3 m (57 ft) and the maximum take-off weight was increased from 25 t (25,000 kg; 55,000 lb) to 28 t (28,000 kg; 62,000 lb).^[86] A static prototype, No. 31002, presumably existed.^[25] The No. 31003 was commonly referred to as the FC-31 V2 by military analysts to distinguish it from the earlier prototype.^[25]

On 29 October 2021, the third flying prototype of the FC-31, tentatively named J-35, conducted its maiden flight.^{[60][61]} The variant featured catapult launch bar, folding wing mechanisms,^[2] modified canopy.^[62] Overall, the "J-35" prototype was largely seen as the developmental continuation of the FC-31 V2.^{[2][63]} On 22 July 2022, the fourth flying prototype, No. '350003', took its maiden flight. It was reportedly the second flying prototype and the third overall prototype of the "J-35" variant, featuring the People's Liberation Army Navy (PLAN) grey camouflage, a more prominent stealth design, and new engines.^{[64][66]}

On 26 September 2023, the land-based variant of the J-35, named J-35A, with a different wing and landing gear design, made its first flight. No aircraft designation number was shown.^{[3][9]} On 13 March 2024, another prototype of the J-35 reportedly flew near Shenyang Aircraft Corporation facilities.^[74]

In the middle of November 2024, the land-based J-35A was publicly unveiled at the Zhuhai air show in China.^[108] The news organisation CNN commented at the time that it was not clear when the J-35A fighter would be commissioned into military use and where the aircraft would then be deployed.^[109]

At the end of May 2025, the Chinese aircraft carrier *Fujian* carried out its eighth sea trial, with ship-borne Shenyang J-35 stealth fighters, fitted for catapult launch, carrying out tests and flights at the same time.^[110]

In June 2025, a prototype with serial number "3506" was observed, which was approaching production standard.^[104]

Production

In May 2025, two prototype aircraft, bearing serial numbers 61820 and 61821, were identified by defense analyst Andreas Rupprecht. The serial number indicated their association with the 1st Air Brigade of the People's Liberation Army Air Force (PLAAF), based in Shenyang. The observation suggested the aircraft may have entered initial production.^[111]

In July 2025, Chinese state media showed multiple J-35 fighters on the assembly line inside a production facility.^{[112][113]}

Export

Pakistan

In January 2024, Pakistan Air Force (PAF) chief Zaheer Sidhu announced Pakistan's intention to buy FC-31 aircraft, and preparations were made for the acquisition.^[114] In December 2024, Pakistani media reported that the PAF approved the purchase of 40 aircraft.^[115]

On 4 June 2025, a Pakistani official told Janes Information Services that pilots had begun training in China for the induction of FC-31 aircraft. Pakistan reportedly planned to acquire 30-40 aircraft with PL-17 missiles, with the first aircraft "begin arriving within months".^[116] On 6 June 2025, Pakistan's government officially announced the country's plan to acquire the J-35A, with the delivery expected in two years.^{[117][118]} The sale would make Pakistan the first export customer of the aircraft type.^[119]

However, in late June 2025, Pakistan's Defense Minister Khawaja Asif denied reports that China would supply J-35A fifth-generation stealth fighter jets to the Pakistan Air Force by 2026, stating in an interview with *Arab News* that "it's only in the media" and beneficial mainly for Chinese defense sales. The reports, which had been widely circulated, suggested that China was expediting the transfer in response to heightened India–Pakistan tensions following the 22 April Pahalgam attack and the subsequent four-day long 2025 India-Pakistan conflict. Asif's remarks dismissed these claims as speculative.^{[120][121]}

Variants

FC-31 No. 31001

First flying prototype.^[11] Export-oriented variant.

FC-31 No. 31003

Second flying prototype.^[25] Export-oriented variant.

J-31B Gyrfalcon

Variant unveiled by Chinese state media in July 2024.^{[16][122]} The J-31B was depicted in the video as significantly larger than the FC-31 prototype, and will have side weapon bays each capable of carrying at least two missiles in addition to a main bay.^[122] The aircraft was reported by Nikkei as being a naval variant, stating that it is expected to be deployed on the aircraft carrier Fujian.^[122] However, an expert quoted by South China Morning Post believed that the J-31B is more likely intended for the People's Liberation Army Air Force.^[16]

J-35

Naval variant, with folded wings and catapult-launch bars for PLAN.^[11]

J-35A

Strategic implications

In 2013, Defense Acquisitions Chief Frank Kendall told a Senate hearing that stolen F-35 data helped U.S. rivals speed up their own fifth-generation fighter projects.^[123] In a 2015 article for the *Diplomat*, Franz-Stefan Gady said that documents leaked to *Der Spiegel* provided the first public confirmation of theft of top secret data of the Joint Strike Fighter program by Chinese hackers.^[124]

U.S. military and industry officials believed in 2014 that once the J-35 (still called FC-31 then) entered service, it would likely be more than a match for existing fourth-generation fighters like the F-15 Eagle, F-16 Fighting Falcon, and F/A-18E/F Super Hornet. They suggested that the capability of the J-35 against the newest fighters, such as the U.S. F-22 and F-35, would depend on factors such as quantity of the platforms, quality of pilots, and capabilities of radars and other sensors.^[125]

Western commentaries also focused on the export potential of the aircraft, suggesting that the J-35 could be attractive to countries that cannot afford the American fighters or face Western export restrictions.^{[79][81][82]} However, regional rivals, including India (HAL AMCA) and Japan (Mitsubishi F-X), were pursuing their own programs to develop fifth and sixth generation fighters to counter China's developments, while some of China's other neighbors were considering purchasing the F-35 or Su-57 to foster their capabilities.^{[126][127][128][129]}

Numerous comparisons have been made between the Chinese J-35 and American F-35, including their similar size, roles, and wing-tail configurations.^{[101][130]} Some potential differences have been reported to be their design structure, internal subsystems, and operational requirements.^{[10][56]} Writing for Air Power Australia in 2014, UK photographer David Bignell claimed that the H/C-31 was modeled after the F-22.^[131] Writing for The Diplomat in 2024, Rick Joe, a longtime follower of Chinese military developments, suggested that while it is "very much plausible" that espionage relating to the F-35 benefited the J-35 program (potentially in the development of mission systems specifically aimed at countering the F-35), detailed forensics of both aircraft would be unlikely to ever occur.^[78]

According to defence news website *19FortyFive*, writing in May 2025, the advanced capabilities of the land-based J-35A and its role in China's military strategy pose a number of challenges for Taiwan in particular.^[132] The stealth capabilities of the aircraft make it difficult for Taiwan's air defense systems to detect and track the planes, thereby making surprise attacks easier for China. And the advanced avionics and weapon systems give China a significant edge should it try to achieve air superiority over Taiwan.

Operators

Chinese military

People's Republic of China

- People's Liberation Army Air Force: J-35A
- People's Liberation Army Navy Air Force (planned)

- Fujian (18) (planned)

Potential sales

Egypt

- In May 2025, Egypt was reportedly considering the purchase of the J-35. Egyptian military officials showed interest in the aircraft during an event celebrating 45th years of military ties between Egypt and China.^[133]

Pakistan

- Pakistan Air Force – 40 aircraft (planned)^{[134][135][136][137]}

Specifications (FC-31 V2 Prototype)

The specifications denote the FC-31 prototype in development, they are approximate, preliminary, and may not be representative of the Shenyang J-35 variants.^[78]

Data from Aviation Industry Corporation of China,^[92] Aviation Week,^[138] Flight Global^[139] unless otherwise attributed

General characteristics

- **Crew:** 1
- **Length:** 17.3 m (56 ft 9 in)
- **Wingspan:** 11.5 m (37 ft 9 in)
- **Height:** 4.8 m (15 ft 9 in)
- **Gross weight:** 17,500 kg (38,581 lb)
- **Max takeoff weight:** 28,000 kg (61,729 lb) ^[86]
- **Fuel capacity:** 7,200 kg (15,900 lb)
- **Powerplant:** 2 × Guizhou WS-13E (FC-31) or Guizhou WS-21 (J-35) afterburning turbofans ^{[64][88]}, 87.2–93.2 kN (19,600–21,000 lbf) with afterburner

Performance

- **Maximum speed:** Mach 1.8
 - Mach 1.14, 1,400 kilometres per hour (870 mph; 756 kn) at sea level
- **Combat range:** 1,250 km (780 mi, 670 nmi) (radius) on internal fuel
 - 1,900 kilometres (1,200 mi) (radius) with air refueling
 - 2,000 kilometres (1,200 mi) (radius) with external fuel tanks
- **Service ceiling:** 16,000 m (52,000 ft)
- **g limits:** +9/-3

Armament

- **Hardpoints:** 6 × internal hardpoints inside weapons bay, 6 × external hardpoints on wings^[140] with a capacity of 2,000 kilograms (4,400 lb) internal,^[140] 6,000 kilograms

(13,000 lb) external, and up to 8,000 kilograms (18,000 lb) total weapons payload,^[140] with provisions to carry combinations of:

- **Missiles:**

- Air-to-air missiles:
 - PL-10 short-range infrared homing
 - PL-15 long range active radar homing
 - PL-17 long-range active radar homing (planned)
 - PL-21 long-range active radar homing (in development)
- Air-to-ground missiles:
 - 8 × supersonic land attack missiles
 - 8 × supersonic anti-radiation missiles
 - 8 × supersonic anti-ship missiles^[86]

- **Bombs:**

- 8 × 500 kg deep-penetration bombs^[86]
- 30 × smaller bombs^[86]

Avionics

- KLJ-7A^[86] AESA radar
- Distributed aperture system (DAS) optical early-warning system^[86]
- Electro-optical targeting system (EOTS) ^[86]

See also

Related development

- Chengdu J-20
- J-XX

Aircraft of comparable role, configuration, and era

- KAI KF-21 Boramae
- Lockheed Martin F-22 Raptor
- Lockheed Martin F-35 Lightning II
- Mikoyan LMFS
- Mitsubishi X-2 Shinshin
- Sukhoi Su-57
- Sukhoi Su-75 Checkmate
- TAI TF-X

Related lists

- List of fighter aircraft
- List of active Chinese military aircraft
- List of aircraft produced by China

Notes

1. The designation was due to the registration number "31001" display on the initial prototype aircraft, later used officially in a promotional video created by Shenyang Aircraft Corporation and aired on China Central Television.^[16]

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